

Rockefeller Archive Center



Strategic Plan 2026-2028



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From the President

The work of government is scrutinized through the electoral process. Businesses are held accountable through the actions of market forces. But despite directing vast resources toward public purposes and influencing the work of the vast nonprofit sector, philanthropy is subjected to comparatively few mechanisms for public scrutiny. By providing funding to the almost two million nonprofit organizations in the United States, philanthropic agencies make decisions that shape our educational, cultural, scientific, spiritual, health, and social service sectors.

At the Rockefeller Archive Center, we believe that philanthropy deserves the same level of thoughtful inquiry that governments and markets receive. Philanthropic institutions help determine which ideas are pursued, which problems receive attention, and which communities receive support. But how are those decisions made? Who sets the priorities? And what do we know about what has been effective and what has not?

These are questions of growing importance, yet philanthropy remains an understudied field. Over the past 100 years, the contours of how philanthropy is structured and how it practices have evolved; understanding the work and influence of this enterprise draws on history, economics, politics, law, management, and public policy without fitting neatly into any one discipline, leaving significant gaps in research, public understanding, and professional practice.

The Rockefeller Archive Center exists to help close those gaps. We preserve the historical record of philanthropy, make it available for independent research, advance archives and information management across the philanthropic sector, and support scholars and practitioners studying philanthropy's history and central and shared issues concerning contemporary practice.

By building and sharing the evidence needed to understand philanthropy over time, we strengthen collective understanding, accountability, and informed decision-making. For philanthropy to serve the public good most effectively, evidence, reflection, and critical inquiry must be fostered to create useful knowledge. The archive remains foundational to this work. Over the next three years, the Rockefeller Archive Center will also use that foundation actively to convene inquiry, connect knowledge and perspectives, and bring what emerges into wider circulation and use. This 2026-2029 strategic plan outlines how we will strengthen the connections between the documentation, knowledge, and partnerships that make that inquiry possible.

James Shulman
President, Rockefeller Archive Center



Our Mission

Advancing knowledge about philanthropy



Our Vision

Philanthropy represents an influential realm of activity that has a unique degree of independence from external accountability. Both the enterprise itself and society benefit from ensuring that the decisions and actions of philanthropic activity are thoughtfully documented, made as visible as possible, and benefit from free and critical inquiry.



↑ Built for the Future

Our work as we create a Rockefeller Archive Center built for the future falls under four goals across three themes.



Strengthen Our Foundations

We will continue to strive for archival excellence, building upon our strength as an institution with field-leading practice models, a commitment to broad and equitable access, and an investment in archival infrastructures. We will support our staff and manage our resources prudently to ensure that the Archive Center thrives as an organization.

Build Communities of Practice

The Rockefeller Archive Center works to create and expand communities of practice in the fields of archiving, philanthropic record-keeping, and the study of philanthropy. Institutions and individuals working in philanthropy and in scholarship operate with unusual degrees of autonomy; knowing that there is profound value in these pluralistic pursuits, we connect people and efforts to strengthen collective action.

Expand Our Reach

As the largest aggregate holder of philanthropic records in the world, we strive to expand our reach by continuing to widen access to our holdings, sharing our expertise and knowledge and the expertise and knowledge of others with whom we work, and convening people from across philanthropy, scholarship, research, policy, practice, and public life to address consequential questions facing the field.



Strengthening Our Foundations



Built for the Future Goal #1

We will maintain and strategically expand an archive that cares for and makes available the records of philanthropic activity and the efforts that those philanthropic activities have impacted.

↓ We will:

- pursue excellence in archival stewardship through a commitment to the highest archival ethics, standards, and best practices and the use of The Rockefeller Archive Center's physical, technological, and human resources for mission-critical activities.
- engage in responsible and focused collecting activities that advance The Rockefeller Archive Center's mission to document the breadth and diversity of philanthropic activities.
- focus archival processing activities on efforts that provide timely access to new acquisitions and substantially increase the broad and equitable discoverability of all the collections in our care.
- cultivate the independent use of archival records by The Rockefeller Archive Center's global user communities through low-touch, high-impact access programs.



Built for the Future Goal #2

We will support our staff and manage our resources prudently to ensure that the Archive Center thrives as an organization.

↓ We will:

- support the cultivation of a cohesive culture, the development of leadership capacity, and the alignment of talent development with the organization's priorities and goals.
- match the financial planning of the organization to the organizational aims and progression of the institution: from its historic origins as a family activity to an activity whose support was borne by a limited set of institutions, to an institution with a charge to serve and support a sector composed of a broad and diverse set of organizations and activities.
- empower staff to work more efficiently and broaden the impact of our work through continuing investment in new technologies and building digital skills across our teams.
- maintain sustainable and well-managed environments that enable staff to thrive, ensuring accessibility, inclusivity, operational efficiency, and the safety and wellbeing of staff, researchers, and visitors.
- align our strategic plan, annual operating plan, departmental goals, and individual staff goals, and report on our progress at regular intervals.





Build Communities of Practice



Built for the Future Goal #3

We will collaborate with colleagues to share knowledge about and support the work of creating and maintaining records of the philanthropic activity of today and tomorrow.

↓ We will:

- support a sustainable network of archivists, information managers, and their colleagues in philanthropic organizations, building on our successful collaboration with a network of colleagues in the Advancing Foundation Archives effort.
- work with colleagues across our communities to optimize the creation and use of information and the capture of institutional memory concerning philanthropy.
- serve as a connective intermediary organization for staff in various functions within philanthropic organizations, beginning with our focus on the creation and use of information and knowledge.





The June 2019 Advancing Foundation Archives conference was planned and co-hosted by records and archives professionals from the Rockefeller Archive Center, the Ford Foundation, the Mellon Foundation, and the Hogg Foundation for Mental Health.

This core group of original AFA partner institutions expanded to include colleagues from the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, Gates Archive, Ralph C. Wilson, Jr. Foundation, and Ruth Lilly Special Collections at Indiana University-Purdue University Indianapolis and a second Advancing Foundation Archives conference, hosted by the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation, was held on October 4th, 2023, in Seattle, Washington.

AFA is poised to grow once again.

The new AFA Network launches in 2027, bringing together resources, education, and community for all who work in records and information management within philanthropic organizations. Members will be able to engage with one another, access shared lessons learned, and participate in convenings to support a collective strengthening of the knowledge pertaining to the sector.





Expand Our Reach



Built for the Future Goal #4

We will work with individuals and institutions across the educational and philanthropic sectors to help build a field of collective inquiry on philanthropy.

↓ We will:

- instigate new (and foster existing) critical exploration of centrally important current and historical issues in philanthropy.
- create a venue for a vibrant, cross-disciplinary community of scholars, practitioners, researchers, and other experts who bring different forms of knowledge and experience to the study of philanthropy.
- contribute to and amplify existing mechanisms and create new ones for bringing knowledge about philanthropy into circulation and use.
- enhance and extend dialogue among practitioners, scholars, researchers, and theorists, in collaboration with other centers of inquiry across the country and around the world.



Introducing

CCIP

The Center for Collective Inquiry on Philanthropy



CCIP constructs sustained, collective inquiry into the consequential questions facing philanthropy. We work with leading institutions across philanthropy, scholarship, research, and public life to connect knowledge, carry learning forward, and turn what could be fragmented insight into cumulative understanding. This work draws on the RAC's archival foundation and experience, with its institutional drive to gather, preserve, contextualize, and activate knowledge. CCIP works with philanthropic practitioners, scholars, and others with relevant perspectives to promote informed and strategic action and greater accountability.

A vision for the future, grounded in history...

CCIP builds on the Rockefeller Archive Center's strong history of practitioner engagement and in-house scholarship, transforming and expanding that expertise to strengthen the community of scholars, thought leaders, and practitioners in the field of philanthropy. It supports inquiry, strategically convenes perspectives from theory and practice, and translates and circulates what emerges so that it can inform policy and practice and help shape philanthropy's future.



These four areas of activity are intertwined and mutually supportive. As an independent institution situated at the intersection of these flows of information, knowledge, and practice, we must also sustain the organizational capacity that makes this work possible by investing in our people, stewarding our resources responsibly, and maintaining the trust of our partners. Stewardship of the archival record provides evidence on which research and inquiry depend, while our work to support the creation and preservation of today's records helps ensure that the philanthropic activity of the present can be studied by future generations. By connecting theory and practice, and circulating useful knowledge, we strengthen collective understanding and help otherwise fragmented knowledge contribute to the whole enterprise.



Our Values



- **Human-Centered:** We respect the dignity, agency, privacy, and expertise of every person who is a part of or interacts with our organization. We foster a culture of empathy and mutual respect, ensuring that our systems and services are designed to be intuitive and supportive. By valuing the unique backgrounds and needs of all our constituents, we fulfill our mission with a commitment to the well-being and success of the people at the heart of our work.
- **Responsible:** We aim to create a sustainable and expansive future by caring for our organization, the archival records we steward, and our world. We responsibly manage our financial resources and support the people whose expertise makes our work possible. We uphold the highest ethical and professional standards in the care and preservation of our collections, ensuring they remain accessible to our global user communities. We manage these resources with a long-term commitment to environmental sustainability, actively working to minimize the ecological impact of our physical facilities and technological infrastructure.
- **Equitable:** We want our collections, services, workplace culture, and facilities to empower and reflect the diverse communities we serve. We proactively dismantle barriers to access and recruitment while evolving our collecting, interpretive, and analytical activities to engage the communities impacted by our work. We design our processes, services, and systems to promote racial, gender, and economic justice, cultural competence, and to address the structural imbalances inherent in historical documentation.
- **Adaptive:** We believe that progress is more important than perfection. Therefore, we embrace change as a fundamental component of our work, intentionally adopting new technologies and processes that extend our reach and enhance users' experiences. We regularly review our policies and systems to reflect new thinking and remain responsive to evolving circumstances. We foster collaboration because we believe that multiple perspectives and experiences bring value to our work.
- **Trustworthy:** We build trust through transparency, accountability, and institutional independence. Through the ethical application of technology, professional standards, and intentional development of processes, we ensure that our systems and services are built on a foundation of observability, integrity, and a commitment to clear, actionable feedback. In support of those who create new knowledge, we uphold the primacy of free exploration and inquiry.

